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# Another Paycheck. Still Broke.

The cold, practical 15-minute money reset  
for the woman who's done with the dread.

START HERE

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# You're not bad with money. You're flying blind.

Money stress is almost never about how much you make. It's about not *knowing* — what's coming, what's due, what's actually left after the bills you forgot about. That fog is what keeps you up at 2 a.m. doing panicked math in your head, and it doesn't get better with more income. It gets better with clarity.

This is not a budget that shames you or a "skip the latte" lecture. It's a cold, 15-minute system that hands you your real numbers, finds where the money's actually leaking, and gives you the exact words for the hardest money conversations. No fluff. Just control.

## THE REAL PROBLEM

You can't calm down about money you can't see. The dread isn't a character flaw — it's your brain reacting to unknowns. We're going to make the unknowns known. That alone drops the panic by half.

## STEP 1

# Your true number

Forget your bank balance — it lies, because most of that money is already promised to bills you haven't paid yet. Here's the only number that matters until your next paycheck:

$$\begin{array}{rcl} \text{Money in the bank now} & \underline{\hspace{2cm}} & \\ - \text{Bills due before next payday} & \underline{\hspace{2cm}} & \\ \hline = \text{Your TRUE number} & \underline{\hspace{2cm}} & \end{array}$$

### THIS IS THE TRUTH

That bottom number — not your balance — is what you actually have to live on. Write it where you'll see it. Every spending decision gets easy once you know it. Most of your panic was about a number you'd never actually calculated.

## STEP 2

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# Where it's actually going

The money doesn't vanish — it leaks, \$6 and \$11 at a time, in spots you've gone blind to. For 7 days, write down **every** dollar that leaves. No judging. Just look.

- **The auto-renews you forgot.** Subscriptions, apps, "free trials" that started charging. This is almost always the biggest leak. Cancel two today.
- **The convenience tax.** Delivery fees, last-minute takeout, the gas-station run. Small, constant, invisible.
- **The "treat" that became a habit.** The daily thing you stopped noticing you buy.
- **The "I'll deal with it later" fees.** Overdrafts, late fees, interest — the broke tax that keeps you broke.

### YOUR RAISE IS HIDING HERE

You don't need to earn more this week — you need to plug one leak. Cancel one auto-renew, kill one habit. That's \$30–\$100/month back, with zero extra hours worked. That's a raise.

### STEP 3

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## The 15-minute weekly money reset

Same time every week (Sunday works). Fifteen minutes. This one habit ends the 2 a.m. panic, because you'll never be surprised again:

- 1 Check your true number.** Money in, minus what's due before next payday. Know it cold before the week starts.

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- 2 List what's due this week.** Every bill, date, and amount. No ambushes. Ambush is where the panic lives.

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- 3 Move something to the cushion.** \$5, \$10, \$20 — whatever you won't miss — into a separate account, the second you get paid.

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- 4 Pick this week's ONE money move.** Cancel a subscription, call about a bill, sell one thing, pack lunch twice. One move, not a life overhaul.

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- 5 Close the laptop.** You're done. You looked, you know your numbers, you made one move. That's the whole job — and the dread is already quieter.

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## STEP 4

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# The money conversations (scripts)

Half of money stress is conversations you're avoiding. Here are the exact words:

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“ **TO YOUR PARTNER (no blame)**

I want us to look at our real numbers together this week — not to fight, just so we both know what's actually going on. Money stress is so much lighter when it's not a secret.

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“ **NEGOTIATING A BILL**

I've been a customer for [X] years and I'm reviewing my expenses. What's the best rate you can offer me to stay? Is there a loyalty or hardship discount?

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“ **SAYING NO TO SPENDING PRESSURE**

That's not in the budget for me right now. (No explanation owed. "Not in the budget" is a complete sentence.)

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“ **ASKING FOR A RAISE**

I'd like to talk about my compensation. Here's what I've taken on and delivered since my last review. What would it take to get to [number]?

## Build the \$20 wall against disaster

The thing that ends money panic isn't a raise — it's a buffer. Even a tiny one turns "catastrophe" into "annoying." Start the wall:

- **Move a small amount the day you're paid** — before it disappears. \$5–\$20 a week. A separate account or envelope, out of sight.
- **Don't touch it** unless it's a true emergency. A \$300 cushion changes your entire nervous system.
- **When the 2 a.m. dread hits:** stop, look at your true number (it's almost always less scary than the fog), pick ONE action for the morning, then put it down — nothing financial gets fixed at 2 a.m. anyway.

### SAY THIS WHEN YOU SPIRAL

"Being stressed about money tonight does not make me bad at money. I know my number, I have a plan, and I'll work it in the daylight."

# Money stress is not a character flaw. It's a math problem.

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And math problems have answers. Know your true number. Plug one leak. Run the 15-minute reset every week. Move \$20 to the wall. You don't need to be rich by Friday — you need to stop flying blind. The fog lifts the moment you look, and you just looked.

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